AMERICAN VOICES

2.4 Samuel "Sam" Houston 1793–1863

Antonio López de Santa Anna 1794–1876

"Santa Anna, living, can be of incalculable [great] benefit to Texas."—Sam Houston



Houston became known as the "George Washington of Texas." The city of Houston was named after him.



Santa Anna called himself the "Napoleon of the West" but left behind a legacy of chaos in 19th-century Mexico.

Not everyone agreed with Sam Houston about the value of Antonio López de Santa Anna's life. When the Texans won the Battle of San Jacinto, many of Houston's soldiers called for the Mexican leader's execution. After all, Santa Anna hadn't shown any mercy to the Texans at the Alamo. But Houston wanted independence for Texas—not revenge.

CONTRASTING PERSONALITIES

Houston and Santa Anna fought on opposite sides during the Texas War for Independence, but they had a number of things in common. Both pursued careers in the military and in politics. And, in the 1800s, both men were legends and dominant figures in the lands they loved—Houston in Texas and Santa Anna in Mexico.

But that's where the resemblance ended. Houston consistently demonstrated his loyalty and duty to the United States. He fought heroically in the War of 1812 under Andrew Jackson, whom Houston considered his mentor. It was Jackson who encouraged Houston to enter politics. While living in Tennessee, Houston was first elected to Congress and later became governor of the state.

Santa Anna, on the other hand, often placed self-interest above duty, switching sides based on what was in it for him. He entered the Spanish army at 16 and fought with Spain when the war for Mexican independence broke out. (Mexico was a Spanish colony at that time.) But in 1821, Santa Anna shifted his loyalty and led the Mexican rebels to independence. As a reward, he was appointed governor of the Mexican state of Veracruz.

In 1833, the Mexican people elected Santa Anna president, but he soon lost interest in the office and left the real governing to his vice president. However, when the vice president began reforming the church, state, and army, Santa Anna was furious because the reforms threatened his interests. In response, he used military force to remove his vice president.

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CRITICAL VIEWING During the Battle of San Jacinto, Houston was shot in the leg but continued to fight. In this painting by William Huddle, called *Surrender of Santa Anna*, Houston lies on a mat with his leg bandaged, while Santa Anna stands before him. Why do you think Houston's men surround Santa Anna?

CLASHING ARMIES

Resuming authority, Santa Anna introduced a less democratic form of government in Mexico and in Texas. The Texans became dissatisfied with their lack of freedom and, in 1835, began a revolution. They called on Houston, who had relocated to Texas, to lead the rebel force.

From the outset, the Texans were outnumbered. They suffered terrible defeats at the Alamo and in the Texas town of Goliad, where about 350 rebels were taken prisoner and executed. The Texans finally seized their chance in 1836 when Santa Anna and a small number of his soldiers arrived at San Jacinto. Houston organized a surprise attack and quickly overpowered the Mexican Army.

For a time after his embarrassing defeat, Santa Anna fell from favor in Mexico. He returned to power eventually, but as you'll see, American troops would once again bring about his downfall.

As for Houston, he became the first president of the Republic of Texas and served as senator after Texas achieved statehood. He'd just been elected its governor when a number of southern states voted to separate from the United States. When Houston refused to allow Texas to join the southern states, he was removed from office.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** In which two areas did both Houston and Santa Anna pursue careers?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did Houston's treatment of the enemy in the Texas War for Independence differ from the way in which Santa Anna treated his prisoners?
3. **EVALUATE** In what way did Santa Anna's character and judgment affect Texas and Mexico?

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